

Session 14: How Biblical Poetry Communicates

Key Takeaways

- Hebrew poetry is shaped into a line-rhythm or verse. It is not metrical (based on syllable counts) but a form of free verse.
- Hebrew poetry uses intentional, creative language (e.g., heavy use of metaphor) with unique word combinations, repetition, patterns, and hyperlinking to other parts of Scripture.
- The biblical authors build out their theology of God's character, essence, and purpose from within their worldview.

The Poetics of Biblical Poetry: Translation and Literary Design of Psalm 29

¹ Give to Yahweh, O sons of God
give to Yahweh glory and strength.
² Give to Yahweh the glory due his name;
worship Yahweh in the majesty of his holiness.

³ The voice of Yahweh is over the waters;
the God of glory thunders,
Yahweh over the mighty waters.

⁴ The voice of Yahweh is powerful;
the voice of Yahweh is majestic;
⁵ the voice of Yahweh breaks the cedars;
Yahweh breaks in pieces the cedars of Lebanon.

⁶ He makes Lebanon leap like a calf,
Mount Sirion like a young wild ox.

⁷ The voice of Yahweh strikes with flashes of fire.
⁸ The voice of Yahweh shakes the desert;
Yahweh shakes the Desert of Kadesh;
⁹ the voice of Yahweh shakes apart the oaks
and strips the forests bare.

And in **his temple** everything shouts, “**Glory!**”

¹⁰ Yahweh sits **enthroned** over **the flood** ;
Yahweh is **enthroned** as King eternal.

¹¹ Yahweh gives **strength** to **his people**;
Yahweh blesses **his people** with peace.

Psalm 29. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

Definitions and Features of Poetry in General

Encyclopedia Britannica defines poetry as “a kind of literature that evokes a concentrated imaginative awareness of one’s experience or emotions by means of well-crafted language that is chosen for its meaning, sound, and rhythm.”

“Poetry is a kind of human language that says more, and says it more intensely than does ordinary language.”

Perrine, Laurence (1968). [*Sound and Sense: An Introduction to Poetry*](#). Harcourt College Publishers. 3-4.

“Poetry conveys thought; there is something the poet wants to communicate. And poetry conveys that thought in a self-conscious manner, through a special structuring of the language that calls attention to the ‘how’ of the message as well as the ‘what.’ In fact, in good poetry, the ‘how’ and the ‘what’ become indistinguishable. As Robert Alter puts it: ‘Poetry ... is not just a set of techniques for saying impressively what could be said otherwise. Rather, it is a particular way of imagining the world.’”

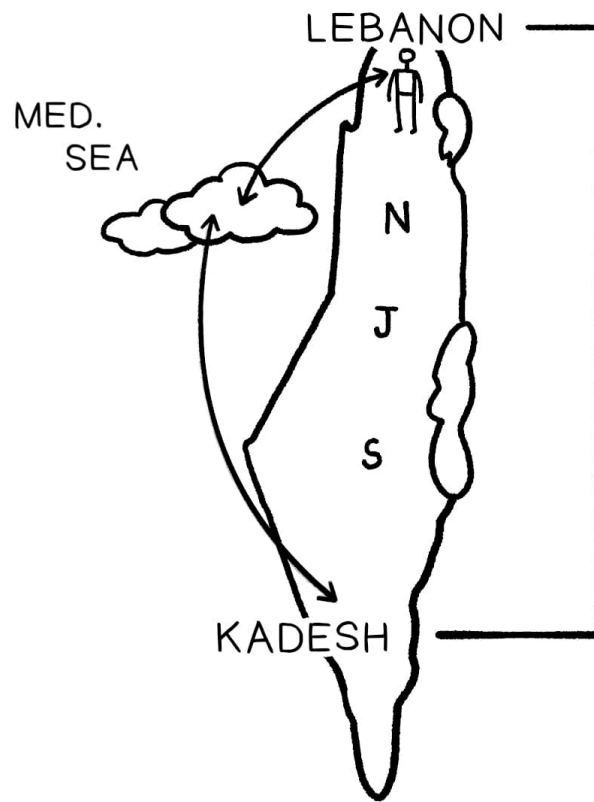
Berlin, Adele (1996). “Introduction to Biblical Poetry.” *New Interpreter’s Bible, Vol. IV*. 301-315.

Typical Features of Poetry

- Density of expression, terseness = fewer words than normal speech
- Intentionally creative use of language (unique word combinations or repetition)
- Heavy use of imagery and metaphor: combining images that don’t normally occur to us (defeat in battle = washed away by chaotic waters)
- Poetry invites you into an imaginative experience in order to communicate more

A rhythmic use of language (meter, rhyme, measure) that places constraints on the poet and forces an economy of expression, a compression of thought so words have to perform unusual functions.

Psalm 29 uses these poetic features to take the reader from the landscape of Israel to the cosmic throne of God where he rules over the storm and the waters.



Rough Map of Israel. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).



God's Throne Over All Creation. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

Reflection Question

Summarize what you've learned so far about how biblical poetry works. What are some of the things to look for as you read?